Hmong Pre-adolescents' Perceptions of Their Family Environment: A Consensual Qualitative Analysis of Family Photos

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Purpose of Study

The purpose of this study was to engage Hmong pre-adolescent children to photograph their home environment to examine what it is like to be Hmong children living in an economically disadvantaged home so change can be made to benefit Hmong children.

Literature Review

❖ Compan, Moreno, Ruiz, & Pascual (2003) found that participants who were more involved in family activities, such as traveling, excursions, attending parties, going to church, engaging in conversations and helping with school work had less mental health issues than the comparison group. The clinical group (those who visited mental health providers) tends to eat fewer meals with their families compared to the nonclinical group.

❖ Anderson, Funk, Elliot & Smith (2003) found that perceived parental support positively predicted participants′ amount of extracurricular involvement.

❖Although the research on family environment and parental involvement is abundant, little research has been done on Hmong family environment.

Methods

Participants

	Free or reduced lunch from school this year.	How well do you speak English?	Number of adults 18 years or older live in your household	Number of children 18 years or younger that live in your household	Years lived in USA	What is your housing situation right now?	Age	Grade	How much have you adopted Americans ways of doing things?
Valid	15	15	15	15	15	15	15	15	15
Mean	1.00	3.2667	4.2667	3.8667	1.53	1.4667	11.73	1.93	2.6000
Std. Deviation	.000	.70373	1.90738	1.64172	.915	.51640	1.668	1.100	.63246

Photovoice Method

Photovoice is a method that allows the participants to capture their own realities from an emic perspective. Thus, we chose to use it in this project because it gave the children the freedom to capture their family environments and tell their own stories.

Procedures and Data Analyses

Participants were recruited from a local Hmong charter school. Interested participants were asked to meet with the research assistant once per month for two hours for three months to build leadership skills, learn about Photovoice method and the ethics of photography, and discuss questions to guide the photography process. The participants were given a digital camera to take pictures at home based on the pre-designed questions.

Consensus qualitative analysis was employed since the research project involved a research team. The research team included four judges and one auditor. The judges coded the data, classified the emerging categories, counted the core ideas across cases, and the auditor verified the analyses prior to reporting.

Results

Domain	Category	Core Ideas	Photos
Structure	Physical Home Environment	Dirty walls**	
		Messy and crowded living space**	
Process	Organization of daily life	Watching TV **	
		Playing with cousins and siblings*	
		Family gatherings**	
	Fancy vs. Practical	Multipurpose room**	
		Using different surfaces for table (beds, chairs, floor, radiators, etc)**	
		Multiple people share a room**	
	Generational and Gender Separation	Older vs. Younger**	
		Children are together**	

*General=all but one case, **Typical=more than half of the cases

❖ Background design by Tou Xiong Xor from Wausau Area Hmong Mutual Association, WI

Discussion

❖ Based on the two domains, 11 categories (i.e., individual vs. family focused, parental involvement, social connection) and 56 core ideas (video games, outdoor activities) emerged from the photos and interviewed transcripts.

❖ Based on the results, we were surprised to find that Hmong families are very innovative and practical. For instance, more than half of the families we studied have pictures of students doing homework on their bed, sofa, or chair and using their space for multiple purposes (i.e., storage).

❖We also found that Hmong families in this study focus more on what is practical versus fancy. For example, many of the photos captured birthday celebrations, however none of the celebrations were filled with balloons, fancy decorations, and presents. Instead, the room was filled with lots of food, people, plastic water bottles, and folding metal chairs.

❖Consistent with the literature on poor families (Lareau, 2002; Weininger & Lareau, 2009), we found that Hmong children's organization of daily life is unstructured and unsupervised by adults. Children spend most of their time after school playing with other siblings and cousins indoors, in front of the television, playing video games, and in the kitchen or outdoors in the park or in their backyard. The only structured activity reported was a school-related program.

❖ Although the findings of the present study provide insight, they cannot be generalized to all Hmong families. Future studies should focus on a more diverse, representative sample to really understand the home environment of Hmong families.

Lessons Learned

❖ Meeting with the students more than once per month would have yielded richer data, since the students needed more directions.

❖ Work on a meeting schedule with the school before the project begins. This would allow the researchers to cultivate a strong relationship with the participants and eliminate much of the confusion toward the end of the study.

❖ Develop a backup plan when working with pre-adolescent children because issues may arise. Being flexible is crucial to a successful study.

❖ Get the support of teachers and school staff early. This allows for a successful completion of the project.

❖It was harder to get the 10 year old students to take pictures and follow directions. We suggest working with participants who are older than 10 years old in future studies.